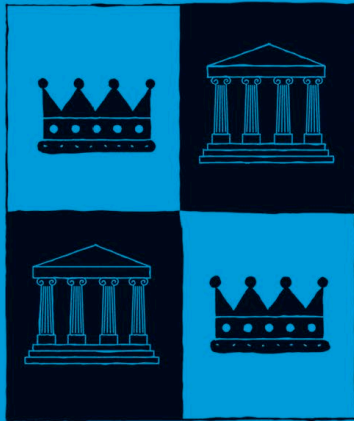




THE RIGHTS AND LIBERTIES OF THE SUBJECT

THE GLORIOUS REVOLUTION AND THE ENGLISH BILL OF RIGHTS (1688–1689)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Constitutional monarchy

BEFORE

1215 England's Magna Carta limits the monarchy's power.

1649 Parliament establishes the High Court of Justice to try Charles I for treason.

1681–1685 Protestant Charles II dispenses with Parliament to rule as an absolute monarch.

1685 Catholic James II succeeds Charles II.

AFTER

1701 The Act of Settlement ensures that only a Protestant can sit on the English throne.

1789 The French National Assembly approves the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen.

1791 The US Bill of Rights is passed; partly inspired by the English Bill of Rights, it guarantees the rights of individuals and of US states.

By the time James II was crowned in 1685, England had long been split by religious and political tensions. During the English Civil War of 1642–1651, James's father, Charles I, had been executed in 1649, when Parliament had declared itself the supreme governing power. Although the monarchy had been restored in 1660 under James's older brother, Charles II, in an uneasy compromise,

questions still remained about the balance of power between monarch and Parliament and about the religious direction of the country. James II was openly Catholic and, for a largely Protestant country such as England, this was problematic.

The strain began to show when in 1687, James issued a Declaration of Indulgence—a royal proclamation giving religious freedom both to Catholics and to Protestants who did not conform to the Church of England. Incensed by protests at his perceived attack on the established Church, James dissolved Parliament in July. In June 1688, while the king prosecuted seven defiant bishops, his Catholic wife, Mary of Modena, gave birth to a son and heir to the throne—fueling fears of a long line of Catholic monarchs and an end to England being a Protestant country.

The Glorious Revolution

As civil war now seemed imminent, a group of politicians wrote to Dutch Protestant ruler William of Orange,



William III and Mary II, shown in an engraving, after ascending to the English throne as joint monarchs—titles granted by agreement with Parliament rather than by the divine right of kings.